COVER STORY

KILLER STRESS

Unhealthy work practices in Indian companies are taking a toll on employees, triggering health issues and sometimes even death

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The Japanese have a word for it—*Karoshi*, or death by overwork. India had a tragic encounter with the phenomenon when a distraught mother wrote to her daughter's boss this September, calling out "a work culture that seems to glorify overwork while neglecting the very human beings behind the roles". It cost their daughter her life. Anna Sebastian Perayil, a bright, young chartered accountant, was just four months into her 'dream job' with SR Batliboi, a member firm of global accounting and consulting firm EY, when she collapsed at home one day, and died. Anna was just 26.

"The workload, the new environment and long hours took a toll on her physically, emotionally and mentally," Anna's mum wrote. "She began experiencing anxiety, sleeplessness and stress soon after joining, but she kept pushing herself, believing that hard work and perseverance were the keys to success.... The relentless demands and the pressure to meet unrealistic expectations are not sustainable, and they cost us the life of a young girl with so much potential."

Anxiety, sleeplessness, stress... It is a feeling familiar to many an Indian employee, and none more than Gen Z, the generation born between 1995 and 2012. A 2023 survey of over 2,000 employees, conducted by online emotional wellness platform YourDOST, found that 60.1 per cent of the respondents reported experiencing high or extreme stress, a 30.3 per cent increase over 2022. It seemed to be the highest in the 21-30 age group, where 64.4 per cent of the respondents complained of high or extreme stress, compared to 53.6 per cent in the 41-50 age group.